India as a Channel to China: Only Hurting Itself? (1951–1952)

Feeling burned by the American attitude and recognizing the adverse impact on the aid debate in Congress, Delhi had limited its intermediary role in the Korean War in spring 1951. Bajpai told Pandit, "Both China and the USA are determined to fight it out, and any third party that tries to come between the two is likely only to hurt itself." There was criticism in parliament of such a role as well. Jivatram Bhagwandas (J. B.) Kripalani, whom Nehru had backed to be president of the Indian National Congress, said that thanks to India's positions, "[India had] no friend left in the world."[238] Furthermore, the experience was frustrating. China and the US mistrusted each other's intentions. Each side told Indian officials they doubted the other's peaceful intentions and, therefore, insisted that the other provide reassurance first.[239]

Nonetheless, in summer 1951, Indian officials did become involved in efforts in Beijing and Delhi—quietly coordinating with British and Swiss representatives—to secure the release of American prisoners being held in China.[240] India was reprising a role it had played in 1949 when it had tried to secure the release of American consul Angus Ward.[241] Differing US and Indian perceptions of China were again evident. In the early stages of talks on the prisoners, Panikkar felt Chinese premier Zhou Enlai's responses were positive. Washington, however, took more seriously the views of British officials, who did not share the Indian ambassador's optimism.[242] There were also differences on tactics. American officials thought that Indian public representations on behalf of the US would convey to Beijing the widespread disapproval of its attitude toward foreign nationals. Indian officials, on the other hand, believed that explicit association with the US or others would reduce Indian influence in Beijing.[243]

Frustration with Washington deepened when India became involved as an intermediary on the Korean issue again, even as China and the US undertook armistice talks after summer 1951 in Kaesong and then Panmunjom. After China backtracked in July 1952 on its in-principle acceptance of an India-UK prisoner repatriation formula that could have led to a settlement, an exasperated Nehru said that both sides "express their desire for settlement, but neither is prepared to give in … and wants the other to do so." He was unhappy that Beijing had not been "straight" with